Mohammad and the Barakzais, even as another arm of the government was secretly backing an uprising against them. As time would show, this approach was not just duplicitous: it was a recipe for diplomatic disaster that would soon blow up in the faces of everyone involved.

On 28 January 1833, ten years after his previous attempt, having armed his men with the new weapons from Delhi, Shah Shuja rode out from Ludhiana at the head of a small force of Rohilla cavalry. He was confident of the success of what would be his third attempt at recovering the throne of Khurasan. ‘I never hesitated to take upon myself difficulties and hardships to regain my kingdom,’ he wrote in his memoirs.

> A treasury of pain has been the reward;
> but the key to that treasury lies with the Almighty:
>
> As long as there is life and a horse, ride it, O Shuja,
> Never lose hope to give a horse the reins.
>
> If a hundred times your heart breaks,
> Still carry on, O Shuja!
>
> Ride with God’s grace and greatness,
> For nothing is impossible to God.[83]

To lead and train his troops, Shuja hired the services of a dogged old Anglo-Indian mercenary named William Campbell. Their first destination was again the financial centre of Shikarpur on the borders of the Punjab and Sindh. The British had advanced Shuja only a fraction of the money he needed to wage war and this time he was determined to be as ruthless as necessary to make sure he would not fail. He showed his intentions as soon as he left British territory by ambushing a caravan of merchants heading to Sindh and seized the goods and baggage camels.[84] With money to hand out, his followers quickly began to increase.

Wade, following at a distance, sent back optimistic reports of the Shah’s progress. Shuja had now gathered 3,000 men ‘of respectable appearance’, he wrote, as well as ‘four pieces of horse artillery, and a treasury with Rs 2 Lakh in it’. There was little doubt, he believed, that this time the Shah would succeed, and, without naming names, went on to ridicule Burnes’s